
GAMING



Google bets on STAN, an Indian social gaming platform



Google has backed **STAN**, an Indian social gaming platform that connects gamers with creators, communities, and publishers.

Google's investment comes as part of an \$8.5 million equity funding round, which also saw investment from Japanese gaming giants Bandai Namco Entertainment, Square Enix, and Reazon Holdings. Aptos Labs and King River Capital, as well as existing backers General Catalyst and GFR Fund, also participated. Google joined the round via its **AI Futures Fund**, which **launched** in May to support startups building with its AI tools.

STAN, headquartered in Singapore, is trying to position itself as a gaming community platform to rival Discord, but its approach to the market is quite different. STAN lets users earn in-app currency called "Gems" by winning games like Krafton's Battlegrounds Mobile India, Garena's Free Fire Max, Minecraft, Call of Duty, or casual titles like Ludo and Snakes & Ladders.

IMAGE CREDITS: JAGMEET SINGH / TECHCRUNCH

The app also lets creators set up chat rooms called Clubs, which are channels tailored for each game on the platform. While anyone can join these Clubs, they need to pay a social currency to access the "gaming experiences" that creators offer. The startup takes a commission from these transactions.

The primary attraction seems to be the in-app currency, however, as it can be redeemed for vouchers on various e-commerce platforms like Amazon, PhonePe, and Flipkart. Users can also earn currency via referrals, a spin-to-win wheel, and daily rewards.

It appears STAN's monetization model is what sets it apart: Users can earn rewards through interactions, unlike on Discord, where chatting or participating in communities doesn't earn users much, apart from clout.

Nonetheless, STAN wants to shadow Discord. The company claims it has already garnered over 25 million downloads on

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the Play Store and App Store altogether, and it has around 5.5 million monthly active users.



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IMAGE CREDITS: STAN

“STAN is the hangout place for gamers. It’s a place where gamers come and make friends, play with each other, talk to each other, sort of a fusion of social and gaming,” said Parth Chadha, co-founder and CEO of STAN, in an interview.

Chadha credits the platform’s features for its traction so far. Initially, creators had to contact the company’s team to start streaming, but last year, the startup opened the platform to user-generated content, allowing anyone to go live. That shift helped drive both downloads and engagement, the CEO said.

STAN also works with game publishers, studios, and developers, including Krafton, Garena, and Roblox, who pay the startup to connect them with gamers and creators on the platform.

Chadha told TechCrunch that in the past two quarters, nearly 100 game publishers, studios, and developers have joined the platform, and it is bringing more than 20 on board each month.

“That is turning into a very interesting business stream as we speak,” he said.

Looking ahead, STAN plans to leverage Google’s backing to use AI to improve moderation.

Currently 70% to 80% of moderation on STAN is already handled by AI, Chadha said. A human moderation team manages the rest, but the startup plans to reduce that further by using AI.

Additionally, STAN aims to bring AI-powered toolkits for creators, including the ability to produce avatars and memes, as well as tools for quick replies and filtering out chats.

“There are a lot of interesting plug-and-play models, which we and the Google team are working together to leverage and scale the business,” he stated.

STAN isn’t the first Indian startup to be backed by Google’s AI Futures Fund. That distinction goes to [Toonsutra](#), a startup using AI to power an [immersive comic-reading experience](#).

Google confirmed to TechCrunch that it has invested over \$5.5 billion in India to date, including in startups Toonsutra, STAN, Pixxel, and Adda247.

Although STAN’s app is currently geo-restricted to India, the platform still sees 5% to 6% of its engagement coming from users abroad, who often access it using Indian phone numbers and accounts. Over the next year, the startup plans to expand internationally, starting with the Indian subcontinent, and will later target Southeast Asia and Latin America.

The startup was profitable for a few months, the CEO said, but decided to spend some money to scale. Now it aims to

achieve profitability in 2027, he added.

Currently, the startup employs about 40 people; less than 30 of them work in product engineering.

With this raise, STAN's total equity funding now stands at around \$15 million.

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Discord acquires
augmented reality startup
Ubiquity6

After raising tens of millions from investors and executing a pretty substantial pivot earlier this year, augmented reality startup Ubiquity6 and its team have been acquired by gaming chat app giant Discord.

The ambitious AR startup had raised \$37.5 million from a series of top investors including Benchmark, First Round, Kleiner Perkins and Google's Gradient Ventures who were betting on its vision of building a consumer-facing platform for hosting augmented reality content. Its most recent publicly disclosed financing was a \$27 million Series B in October of 2018.

Terms of the Discord acquisition weren't disclosed, though in recent months the startup seemed to abandon most of the products it had spent its first several years building, suggesting that Ubiquity6 had been having some issues finding wide audiences for its products.

Ubiquity6 nabs \$10.5 million from top investors to build a deeper augmented reality



Smartphone AR is available on hundreds of millions of devices but it doesn't really seem like many of those devices are making regular use of the feature. A lot of people in the industry see this as representative of the platform's technical shortcomings especially in regards to enabling social experiences. Ubiquity6 is approaching some of ... [Continue reading](#)



Launching back in 2017, Ubiquity6 hoped to build an app that would be the central way mobile phone users would browse augmented reality content. In late 2019, the startup [launched a product called Displayland](#), which aimed to gamify the process of 3D scanning physical environments with a smartphone's camera.

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The company’s efforts to find mass adoption were hampered by a mobile AR market, which has largely failed to gain any momentum in recent years despite hefty investment from tech giants, including Apple and Google.

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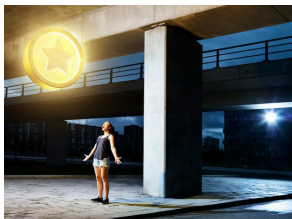
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In early 2020, CEO Anjney Midha told TechCrunch that the startup had some 65 employees.

VCs discuss gaming’s biggest infrastructure investment opportunities in 2021



We last polled our network of investors on the topic of gaming infrastructure startups back in May just as it was becoming clear what pandemic opportunities were in store for gaming startups. Accel’s Amit Kumar told us at the time that “social and interactivity layers spanning across these games” were poised to

be the big ... Continue reading

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In recent months, Ubiquity6 had executed a pretty drastic pivot, leaving augmented reality completely behind in favor of building out a desktop platform that allowed users to play simple online party games together remotely. The beta platform, called [Backyard](#), was designed for pandemic era habits that seem to be on the decline as the US springs back into action. Backyard was discontinued this week as part of the acquisition announcement.

In a [Medium post](#) announcing the acquisition, Midha seems to downplay any expectations that Ubiquity6's augmented reality technology will be living on inside Discord.

"Our mission at Ubiquity6 has always been to unlock new ways for people to connect through shared experiences," Midha wrote. "Joining Discord today allows us to accelerate that mission — Ubiquity6's team, Backyard product and multiplayer technology will be integrated into Discord."

Ubiquity6 launches a studio editor built for the real world



"The time is over for Unity," Ubiquity6 CEO Anjney Midha says. "It's just not the future." Even though 2019 was a rough year for augmented reality startups, Ubiquity6 remains ambitious as one of the better-capitalized players in the space. In 2018, the startup closed \$27 million from Benchmark and Index Ventures; they've raised \$37.5 million ... [Continue reading](#)

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Krafton backs Indian influencer marketing platform One Impression in \$10M funding

Jagmeet Singh — 9:30 PM PDT · March 14, 2023

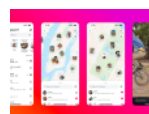
One Impression, an Indian influencer marketing platform that does business in markets including Indonesia, Dubai, Europe and the U.S., has raised \$10 million in a funding round led by the South Korean gaming company Krafton.

The Gurugram-based startup is building an Amazon-like platform to help brands quickly find relevant influencers for their marketing campaigns. It touts having more than 7 million content creators on the platform that brands ranging from FMCG to e-commerce can access. These creators include the micro-ones developing content from villages and tier-2 and tier-3 towns, as well as large celebrities and even Bollywood actors that generate more than 100,000 content pieces for more than 500 brands in over 10 languages. The platform is also not limited to influencers from a particular genre and has creators in comedy, beauty, fashion and DIY, among other fields.

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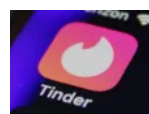
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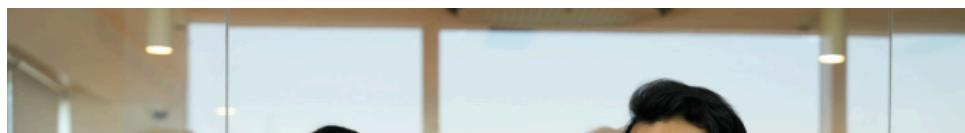
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“We ensure the right pricing for every influencer, and as a platform, we ensure that as a brand, you get the best match and the best price for every creator that you work with,” said Apaksh Gupta, co-founder and CEO, One Impression, in an interview with TechCrunch.

Founded in 2018 by Gupta and his brother Jivesh Gupta, [One Impression](#) works directly with content creators, agencies and agents to offer brands a range of influencers to fit their requirements. This is unlike a traditional influencer marketing agency or a creator discovery tool, where you typically find just a single source to pick. Also, the startup offers full-stack solutions ranging from discovery, pricing and payments to compliance, government contracts, delivery and performance tracking.

“We’re bridging the gap between brands and creators. We’re trying to make the partnerships between brands and creators the most seamless, fastest, repeatable and scalable,” the executive said.



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Photo-sharing app Locket is banking on a new celebrity-focused feature to fuel its growth

Lauren Forristal

- 18 hours ago

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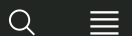
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One Impression is building tools for creators to help them monetize their content and unlock opportunities to collaborate with other creators and make finance easier using automation. The startup is also working on tools to let creators easily access studios across India and even get PR opportunities, said Gupta.

Currently, One Impression has enabled its platform for Instagram and YouTube. It also plans to unlock it for LinkedIn

and Moj in India and TikTok for global markets over time.



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“As different platforms continue to become important for any market, we’ll continue to integrate those new platforms into our platform,” Gupta said.

One Impression takes a fee from brands for connecting them with influencers and charges commissions to content creators that grow once the creators become more relevant for large-scale campaigns. This makes it a two-sided marketplace for both brands and creators. It is also working on launching premium tools to offer brands a subscription-based model for regular earnings.

The Krafton-led, all-equity Series A funding round also saw participation from PeerCapital. It valued the startup at \$70 million post-money.

On whether the investment coming from Krafton was strategic, Gupta told TechCrunch that the gaming giant has come as a financial investor.

“The creator ecosystem is at the cusp of a revolution. It holds massive untapped potential, and we believe that One Impression is rightly positioned to be a global leader of the influencer industry. One Impression has an ambitious vision for the space, and we are delighted to support them in their journey,” said Sean Hyunil Sohn, CEO of Krafton India, in a prepared statement.

Since 2021, Krafton has invested [over \\$100 million in various Indian startups](#) to become more than a gaming company. However, the company has faced the [banning of its widely popular gaming title Battlegrounds Mobile India \(BGMI\)](#) in the country — just months after it struggled to bring its original PUBG Mobile title back that also got [banned by the Indian government](#) in 2020 over national security concerns.

“At Krafton, we are committed to the Indian market and see tremendous potential here. We have invested around \$100 million in various Indian startups since 2021. And our investment in One Impression is a step towards augmenting this ecosystem and creating opportunities of growth,” Sohn said.

One Impression, which claims to have created a profitable business without marketing, plans to utilize the fresh funds to build a marketing team and scale its sales team to expand its presence in global markets, starting with Southeast Asia and the UAE. It also looks to make acquisitions in Dubai to boost its market presence. The planned expansion is projected to help the startup grow its average revenue rate to \$40 million.

In 2022, One Impression raised \$1 million from angels, including Peeyush Bansal of Lenskart, Anupam Mittal of People Group and celebrities such as Olympian Neeraj Chopra and comedian Zakir Khan, among others.

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Under-the-radar payments app True Balance just clocked \$100M in GMV in India

Manish Singh — 4:41 AM PDT · May 29, 2019

IMAGE CREDITS: TRUE BALANCE

Away from the limelight of urban cities, where an increasingly growing number of firms are fighting for a piece of India's digital payments market, a South Korean startup's app is quietly helping millions of Indians pay digitally and enjoy many financial services for the first time.

The app, called [True Balance](#), began its life as a tool to help users easily find their mobile balance, or topping up pre-pay mobile credit. But in its four-year journey, its ambition has significantly grown beyond that. Today, it serves as a digital wallet app that helps users pay their mobile and electricity bills, and it also lets users pay later.

One thing that has not changed for the parent company of True Balance, BalanceHero, which employs less than 200 people, is its consumer focus. It is strictly catering to people in tier-two and tier-three markets — often dubbed as India 2 and India 3 — who have relatively limited access to the

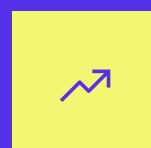
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internet, and lower financial power. And it remains operational just in India.

Even as India is already the second largest internet market with [more than 500 million users](#), more than half of its population remains offline. In recent years, the nation has become a battleground for Silicon Valley giants and Chinese firms that are increasingly trying to win existing users and [bring the rest of the population online](#).

And like many other companies, BalanceHero's bet on India is beginning to pay off. The startup told TechCrunch today that it has clocked \$100 million in GMV sales and has amassed about 60 million registered users. Yongsung Yoo, a spokesperson for the startup, added that BalanceHero, which has raised \$42 million to date, is also nearing profitability.

The South Korean firm's playbook is different from many other players that are racing to claim a slice of India's burgeoning digital payments market. True Balance competes with the likes of Paytm, MobiKwik, Google, Amazon and Walmart-owned Flipkart, though its competitors are still largely catering to the urban parts of India.

In the last two years, many firms have begun to [explore smaller cities and towns](#), but their services are still too out-of-the-world for local residents. Raising awareness about digital services is a big challenge in such markets, Yoo said, so the startup is relying on existing users to help others make their first transactions and in paying bills.

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Yoo said the startup rewards these “digital agents” with cash back and other benefits. For these digital agents, many of whom do not have a day job, True Balance has emerged as a side project to make extra money.

Later this year, Yoo said the startup, which recently also added support for UPI in its service, will open an e-commerce store on its app and also offer insurance to users. To accelerate its growth and expansion, True Balance is in the final stages of raising between \$50 million to \$70 million in a new round that it expects to close in July this year, Yoo said.

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Manish Singh is a senior reporter at TechCrunch, covering India’s startup scene and venture capital investments. He also reports on...

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